SUPPLIER GUIDE

BONUS 5



Where to Buy Beads & Findings: The Supplier Guide

How to choose suppliers, build a smart first order, and stop wasting money on the wrong beads

Walk into the world of seed beads for the first time and it can feel like walking into a hardware store with no list. Hundreds of colors, dozens of finishes, tubes and hanks and little bags that all look alike, and prices that seem to jump around for no reason. It is easy to spend forty dollars and come home with a pile of beads that do not go together and a missing clasp.

This guide is the list you wish you had. It does not push you toward one shop. Instead, it teaches you how to judge any supplier, what to buy where, how to avoid waste, and how to build a first order that actually gets you making jewelry the same week it arrives.

A quick honesty note: prices, stock and shipping policies change constantly, and we cannot see them from here. Everywhere we mention a supplier, treat it as a place worth looking, then check current prices and stock yourself before you order. We have no affiliation with any shop named here, and every dollar figure in this guide is an example to help you plan, not a quote.

1. Chapter 1: How to Judge a Supplier Before You Spend a Dollar

A good supplier is not simply the cheapest one. It is the one that gives you beads you can rely on, a clear idea of what you are getting, and a delivery that arrives without drama. Before your first order, run any shop through four questions: Are the beads consistent? Is the product described clearly? Is the shipping fair and predictable? And if something goes wrong, is there a sensible way to fix it?

Consistency matters more in seed beadwork than almost anywhere else in crafting. A Delica 11/0 is a tiny cylinder, roughly 1.6 mm long, and your stitches depend on neighboring beads being nearly identical in size. When sizes wobble, rows buckle, peyote stitch turns wavy, and a flat bracelet starts to curl. Japanese-made cylinder beads have a long reputation for tight tolerances, which is why so many people choose them for delicate, even work. Round 11/0 seed beads are more forgiving but still vary from lot to lot.

> **THE FOUR-POINT SUPPLIER CHECK**
>
> 1) Consistency: do reviews mention even sizing, or do they mention 'a few misshapen beads'? 2) Description: does the listing state bead type, size (such as 11/0), finish, and quantity by weight or count? 3) Shipping: are costs and timing clear before checkout? 4) Returns: is there a stated policy for wrong or damaged items? If a shop fails two of these, keep looking.

Learn to read a listing the way a buyer reads a label. You want to see the bead family (Delica cylinder, round seed bead, charlotte cut, and so on), the size, the color name or number, the finish, and the amount. Amounts come in several forms: a small tube or vial, a packet of 5 or 7.2 grams, a larger bag of 10 to 50 grams, or a hank, which is a bundle of strung strands. Always check which one the price refers to, because the cheapest-looking listing is often the smallest amount.

Finish matters just as much as color. Matte, opaque, metallic, galvanized, AB (the shimmering rainbow coating), and lined or dyed beads all behave a little differently over time. Plated and dyed finishes can rub or fade with heavy wear, especially on bracelets and rings. That is not a flaw to panic about, but it is worth checking the shop's notes and choosing durable finishes for pieces that will take a beating.

Practice task: read three listings

Open any three bead listings from different shops. For each one, write down the bead type, size, finish, exact amount, and the price per gram or per tube. Which one is truly the best value once you compare like for like? This ten-minute habit will save you more money than any coupon.

2. Chapter 2: What to Buy Where

No single shop is best at everything. Specialty bead sellers shine at seed beads and findings. Big marketplaces shine at convenience and tools. Craft stores shine at same-day emergencies. Match the item to the kind of seller and you will pay less and get better quality.

What you need	Best place to look	Why
Delica 11/0 and other Japanese cylinder beads	Specialty bead suppliers and dedicated bead shops (including international sellers of Japanese beads)	Wider color range, accurate color names, and consistent lots
Round seed beads 11/0 and 15/0	Specialty bead suppliers, Etsy bead shops	Good variety, and small sellers often sell by the gram
Clasps, jump rings, ear wires, crimps	Jewelry-findings suppliers	Better metal quality and clear material descriptions
Thread, needles, thread burners	Bead suppliers, craft stores, large marketplaces	Basic items that are easy to compare and replace
Mats, trays, tweezers, scissors	Large marketplaces and craft stores	Generic tools are cheap and widely available
Gift boxes, bags, cards	Packaging suppliers and large marketplaces	Bulk packs bring the per-piece cost way down
Display cards, bust forms, stands	Large marketplaces and craft stores	Wide choice and fast shipping

Seed beads are the heart of your work, so spend your attention there. Buy them from sellers who specialize in beads, who state the size and finish clearly, and whose reviews talk about the beads rather than only about shipping speed. For findings, material is the key word. Look for clear descriptions such as sterling silver, gold-filled, stainless steel, brass, or plated base metal, and be wary of listings that say only 'silver color' or 'gold tone' without telling you what is underneath.

Thread and needles deserve a moment too. For most delicate beadwork, a nylon beading thread in a fine size (many people reach for size D) or a braided fused line in the 6 to 8 lb range does the job, paired with beading needles in sizes 11 to 13. Brand and exact weight vary from seller to seller, so read the label and compare. If you are just starting, buy one spool of a neutral color and a small pack of needles. Needles bend and break, so a pack of several is better than a single needle.

> **BUY FINDINGS THAT MATCH YOUR BEADS**
>
> Tiny beadwork looks best with small, light findings. A chunky clasp can overpower a delicate Delica bracelet. When choosing findings, think about weight and scale first, then metal color. Buy one extra metal tone to start, usually silver or gold tone, so your pieces share a consistent look.

3. Chapter 3: Real Suppliers, Honestly Described

Below is a list of well-known places where US beaders shop. Descriptions are general and based on what these businesses are widely known for. Their catalogs, prices, stock and policies change often, so treat this as a starting map, then check current prices and stock yourself before you order. Mention here is not an endorsement, and we have no connection to any of them.

Supplier	What they are generally good for	Before you order
Fire Mountain Gems and Beads	Very large catalog covering seed beads, findings, tools and packaging; frequently used for bulk and for wide choice of findings	Check current prices, minimums and shipping; compare per-gram cost with smaller shops
Beadaholique	Beading supplies and findings with a beginner-friendly feel and plenty of how-to content	Check current prices and stock for specific colors
Artbeads	General jewelry-making supplies, including seed beads, findings and tools	Check current prices, stock and shipping options
Rings & Things	Findings, beading wire, clasps, tools and beads for jewelry makers	Check current prices and what is actually in stock
Amazon	Convenience for tools, thread, mats, packaging and fast delivery; also some bead assortments	Quality varies a lot between sellers; read reviews carefully and watch for mixed or unbranded lots
Etsy bead shops	Small sellers with curated colors, hand-sorted sets, and often Japanese beads sold by the gram or in color-matched kits	Check each shop's reviews, processing time and shipping, as these vary a great deal
Craft-store basics (national craft chains)	Emergency thread, needles, glue, display items and basic tools, plus coupons	Check the selection; seed bead colors are usually limited and prices can be high per gram

A word about international sellers. Many of the most widely available Japanese seed beads and cylinder beads are sold by shops based in other countries, including bead sellers in Asia and Europe, which list on marketplaces or run their own online stores. They can offer a wide color range and attractive prices, but you will want to look closely at three things: shipping time, whether customs or import fees may apply to your order, and the shop's return policy. These details differ from seller to seller, so read them before you check out.

Toho beads are a respected alternative to Miyuki and are widely sold in the same places. They are very close in feel, though sizes and colors do not match one-for-one, so avoid mixing the two brands in a single narrow piece unless you test a sample row first.

> **A SIMPLE WAY TO COMPARE SUPPLIERS**
>
> Pick one bead you want, such as a particular Delica 11/0 color, and look it up at three shops. Write down the amount and total price including shipping. Dividing the price by the grams gives you a price per gram. Do this once and you will understand how each shop prices, which is far more useful than any coupon.

4. Chapter 4: Buying in Bulk Without Waste

Bulk sounds like saving, and sometimes it is. A bigger bag often costs less per gram. But bulk becomes waste the moment you buy 50 grams of a color you will use 3 grams of. The trick is to buy small first, learn what you actually use, and scale up only the winners.

Here is a useful rule of thumb. A small bracelet in Delica 11/0 may use only a few grams of beads, and a pair of earrings often uses less than that. Yet exact amounts depend on the stitch, the width and the length, so confirm with your own test pieces. As you complete your first few projects, weigh what you used on a cheap kitchen scale or jewelry scale and write it in your notebook. After five projects, you will know how much you need for any design.

- Buy neutral base colors (black, white or cream, a metallic) in larger amounts, since they appear in nearly every design.
- Buy accent colors in small tubes or packets until a pattern calls for more.
- Buy findings in packs of 10 to 25 once you have settled on your favorite style and metal.
- Buy packaging in bulk only after you have sold or gifted at least a few pieces and know what size you really need.
- Keep a 'wish list' of colors instead of buying them on impulse; wait one week before adding to a cart.

Another smart bulk method is the shared order. If you have a friend who also beads, splitting a bigger bag of a staple color lets you both enjoy the lower per-gram price without being stuck with too much. A few bead shops also sell mixed color packs that can be cost-effective, but be careful. Mixes are great for practice and for bracelet patterns that use many colors, and less ideal when you need a precise, matching palette.

Practice task: the usage log

For your next three projects, weigh your beads before and after, and record the grams used per piece. Add the numbers to a simple page in your notebook: project, bead color, grams used. After three entries you will know where to buy in bulk and where to stay small.

5. Chapter 5: Color Lots and Matching

Here is a lesson most beaders learn the hard way. Two tubes of the 'same' bead can look slightly different if they come from different production batches, which are called lots. For many colors the difference is invisible. For some, especially metallics, galvanized and AB finishes, and certain pastels, it can be noticeable once the beads sit side by side in one row.

This matters most when you plan to make a set, repeat a bestselling design, or finish a project you started weeks ago. If you run out halfway through a wide bracelet and reorder, the new beads might not match the old ones perfectly.

> **HOW TO PROTECT YOUR PALETTE**
>
> 1) For any project you care about, buy a little more than you think you need. 2) Keep the original tubes and labels so you can reorder by exact color number. 3) Mix beads from several tubes of the same color into one container before using them, which blends small differences evenly. 4) If you sell a design, buy enough of the key colors for several pieces at once from the same order.

Color names and numbers are your friend. Seed bead makers list each color by a code, and shops usually include that code in the listing. Copy the code into your notes along with the shop name and the date. A photo of the tube on your table, with its label showing, takes five seconds and can save a whole project later.

Screens also lie. A color that looks soft sage on your monitor can look gray on the table. If a color is critical, buy a small sample before a large amount, or look for a shop that shows photos of beads in daylight or on a neutral background. Customer photos in reviews are often the most truthful of all.

- Write the color code, shop name and date on every tube or bag.
- Keep a swatch card: tape one or two beads next to the code in your notebook.
- Store leftover beads of the same code together, never mixed with other colors.
- When matching an old project, compare in natural daylight, not under yellow lamps.

6. Chapter 6: Your First Order, Budgeted

Time to turn all this into a shopping list. The two starter lists below are examples to help you plan. Prices change and vary by shop, so the amounts shown are rough, illustrative planning numbers and not quotes. Before ordering, check current prices and stock for every item. Adjust the list to your own taste and to the patterns you plan to make first.

The $50 list is meant for a person who wants to try the craft, finish two or three small projects (a bracelet and a pair of earrings, for instance), and see whether the hobby sticks. The $100 list adds more color, extra findings, and a few tools to make the work comfortable and ready to share or sell.

Item ($50 starter, example)	Suggested amount	Example budget
Delica 11/0 in 4 colors (1 neutral base, 1 metallic, 2 accents)	Small tubes or packets, 5 to 7 grams each	$18 to $24
Round 11/0 seed beads in 1 or 2 colors	One tube or small bag each	$4 to $7
Beading thread (nylon size D or braided 6 to 8 lb)	1 spool	$4 to $7
Beading needles, sizes 11 to 13	1 pack of several	$3 to $5
Bead mat or small tray	1	$4 to $7
Small scissors or thread cutter	1	$3 to $5
Clasps and jump rings in 1 metal tone	A few of each	$4 to $7
Ear wires in 1 metal tone	A small pack	$3 to $5

Item ($100 starter, example)	Suggested amount	Example budget
Delica 11/0 in 8 to 10 colors, including 2 neutrals and 1 or 2 metallics	Small tubes or packets, 5 to 7 grams each; larger amount for the main neutral	$40 to $55
Round 11/0 and 15/0 seed beads for edging and filler	A few small tubes	$8 to $12
Beading thread in 2 colors (neutral and dark)	2 spools	$8 to $12
Beading needles, sizes 11 to 13	2 packs	$5 to $8
Bead mat, tray, tweezers, thread burner or cutter	1 of each	$10 to $15
Clasps, jump rings, ear wires in 2 metal tones	Small packs	$10 to $15
Simple packaging: small boxes or bags and cards	A starter pack	$5 to $10

WHERE TO CUT IF YOUR BUDGET IS TIGHT

Protect the beads, thread and needles first, since they decide the quality of your work. If you need to trim, skip fancy tools and extra packaging until you have finished a few pieces. A plain dish or a folded towel works as a bead mat in a pinch.

7. Chapter 7: Storage and Organization

Seed beads are small, but a collection grows faster than you expect. Good storage protects your investment, keeps colors easy to find, and keeps tiny beads out of carpets and cat bowls. You do not need a fancy setup. You need a system you will actually use.

- Keep beads in their original tubes until you have a better container; the label holds the color code.
- Use small screw-top jars or clear plastic organizers with snap lids for open stock.
- Group by color family first, then by size or brand within the family.
- Label every container with the color code, shop and date.
- Store away from direct sunlight and damp, which can dull some finishes over time.
- Work over a bead mat or tray with a raised edge so a dropped bead does not roll away.

Findings need their own homes. Small zip bags or compartment boxes work well, sorted by type (clasps, jump rings, ear wires) and labeled by metal. Mixing metals invites mistakes, so label clearly. Keep tarnish-prone metals in sealed bags and away from humid rooms such as bathrooms.

Keep a working kit and a stock shelf. The working kit is a small tray or box holding the beads, thread, needle and tools for your current project. Everything else stays on the shelf. When a project is done, return beads to their jars the same day. Ten minutes of tidying after each session is easier than a three-hour sort once a month.

> **THE ONE-PAGE INVENTORY**
> Keep a single sheet or spreadsheet with four columns: color code, color description, approximate grams left, and where you bought it. Update it whenever you open a tube or finish a project. It will tell you what to reorder before you run out.

8. Chapter 8: Tracking Suppliers and Spotting Red Flags

Once you are ordering regularly, a small tracking worksheet turns a pile of receipts into useful knowledge. You will see which shops deliver on time, whose beads are consistent, and who is worth reordering from. Copy the table below into a notebook or a spreadsheet and fill in one row per supplier.

Supplier	What I buy there	Typical cost (example)	Delivery time	Quality notes	Reorder? (yes / maybe / no)

Add a short note after each order: Did the package match the listing? Were the beads evenly sized? Was anything missing or damaged? Over time those notes become a private ranking of your suppliers, which is more valuable than any list written by a stranger.

> **RED FLAGS WORTH WALKING AWAY FROM**
>
> Be careful with listings that show no clear size or bead type; prices far below every other shop for the same item; reviews that all sound alike or never mention the beads themselves; vague descriptions of materials for findings; no stated shipping time or return policy; and shops that pressure you to buy quickly. Any one of these is a reason to pause, and two together are a reason to leave.

- Photos that look like stock images rather than the actual beads.
- Mixed lots described as one single color.
- Findings sold as 'silver' with no mention of what the metal really is.
- Sellers who do not answer a simple pre-purchase question.
- Payment requests outside the platform you are shopping on.

Protect yourself in simple ways. Pay with a method that offers buyer protection, keep your order confirmations until the goods arrive and prove satisfactory, and photograph any problem right away. A polite message with a photo usually gets the fastest fix.

Practice task: rank your top three

After your first two or three orders, fill in your tracking sheet and mark each supplier yes, maybe or no. Choose one favorite for seed beads, one for findings, and one for tools and packaging. Those three become your regular sources, and you can stop shopping around on every order.

Next steps

You do not need to find the perfect shop. You need a few reliable ones, a clear list, and the habit of checking before you click. Start small, keep notes, and let your own projects tell you what to buy more of.

Remember that prices and stock change, so always check current details before ordering. With a sensible first order in your cart and a tidy place to keep your beads, the only thing left is to start stitching. Happy beading from all of us at Tiny Bead Studio.

Supplier tracker

Log what you buy, where, and how it arrived.

Supplier	Item	Price	Shipping / time	Rating (1–5)